



Guiding transition: Indian hockey great P.R. Sreejesh oversees his first major assignment as junior coach, using the World Cup to test both results and the development pathway. HOCKEY INDIA

important for them to have a long vision about their career," the two-time Olympic bronze medallist explained. "This is a place where they gain experience, playing in front of a huge crowd. They will learn to control themselves and execute the simple, basic things under pressure."

All 18 members of India's squad are part of Hockey India League teams, and many have already experienced packed stadiums. Still, performing in a franchise league and representing the country on home soil are entirely different challenges.

For India, success will hinge on the mental game and on transforming the weight of expectations and the crowd's energy into fuel for a deep run.

"The team is very confident with the way we have prepared for this tournament, and we will continue our training to ensure we are fully ready for the challenges ahead," said defender Amir Ali.

The 14th edition features a revamped structure, with 24 teams from six continents competing for the title.

India, drawn in Pool B, opens its campaign against Chile, followed by matches against Oman, which replaced Pakistan, and Switzerland.

The colts are widely expected to top their group and secure a clear path to the quarterfinals. Yet they must remain sharp from the outset,

since one lapse can derail two years of preparation.

Performances in Malaysia highlighted vulnerabilities, particularly against fast counter-attacks. Losses to Australia, including the final, and a draw against Pakistan, illustrated how strong opponents offer few opportunities for recovery.

This sets up a strategic dilemma for Sreejesh: whether to lean on the traditional flair and skill that define Indian hockey or adopt a more structured, possession-oriented approach common in Europe. He prefers a pragmatic, situation-based method. "It will depend on the opposition. Against teams which will defend deep, we have to play in a certain way. Against teams which will employ zonal or man-to-man marking, we will have to adapt accordingly. I don't want the players to relinquish the Indian skill-based style, but also don't want to be boxed in one category," Sreejesh concluded.

India's real test is likely to emerge in the quarterfinals, when the squad encounters top-tier opponents.

As the senior national team navigates a transition, the spotlight now turns to the next generation. This is not just a chance for them to experience a major event. It is their defining moment, the opportunity to make the leap that places them at the heart of Indian hockey's future.



A quiet revival gathers pace

Two years after hosting the Asian Champions Trophy, Tamil Nadu is preparing for another premium event as the FIH Junior Men's World Cup 2025 brings global hockey back to the Coromandel coast for the first time in 17 years.

The Mayor Radhakrishnan Stadium in Chennai will co-host the tournament with a newly built hockey complex at the Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu (SDAT) facility in Madurai.

"The Government of Tamil Nadu had a wonderful collaboration with FIH and Hockey India during the Champions Trophy. The idea [of hosting this World Cup] was to ensure the tournament reaches different parts of the State. Madurai already had a hockey turf and is adjacent to areas like Kovilpatti, Virudhunagar and Ramanathapuram, which are renowned for their hockey culture," said Meghanatha Reddy IAS, Member Secretary, SDAT.

"Hosting a global tournament helps spruce up the infrastructure in the area, which will serve the people for the next 20 years at least. Players from close to 12 teams will be playing in Madurai. This will be a huge inspiration for the budding talent who wish to take up the game," he added.

P.R. Sreejesh, double Olympic medallist and head coach of the men's junior team, echoed that sentiment, backing the push to take big-ticket events to "hearts of cities and villages".

"Conducting tournaments in the remote areas will help kids get a closer view of the sport, the intensity and the speed of play. When they dream about playing for our country, these experiences are going to show them the realistic way," the former India goalkeeper said.

The Tamil Nadu government has allocated Rs. 25 crore to build the new Madurai stadium, which includes a world-class pitch and upgraded lighting. Another Rs. 7 crore has gone into improving the Chennai venue with tensile roofing and new seating.